

US applications: Key terms

Know your Major from your Minor and your Frat from your SAT



Even if you don't get in, applying for college in the USA will at least expand your vocabulary. Here are the terms you need to know.

Term	Explanation
ACT	A standardized college admission test. It features four main sections: English, math, reading, and science — and an optional essay section.

Admission Tests	Also known as college entrance exams, these are tests designed to measure students' skills and help colleges evaluate how ready students are for college-level work. The ACT and the College Board's SAT are two standardized admission tests used in the United States. The word "standardized" means that the test measures the same thing in the same way for everyone who takes it.
AP (Advanced Placement program)	A program offered by the College Board, a U.S.-based nonprofit educational organization, that allows students to take college-level courses while in high school. Students can then take standardized AP exams; those with qualifying scores can earn credit at certain colleges and universities.
Articulation Agreement	An agreement between two-year and four-year colleges that makes it easier to transfer credits between them. It spells out which courses count for degree credit and the grades you need to earn to get credit.
Bachelor's Degree	This is the degree that a student will get after graduating from a 4-year undergraduate program at a US university.
Binding	This is the term used to say that attending the university will be an obligation and not a choice. Applications that are ED are binding while applications that are EA or RD are non-binding.

**Candidates Reply
Date Agreement
(CRDA)**

An agreement many colleges follow that gives applicants until May 1 to accept or decline offers of admission. This agreement gives students time to get responses from most of the colleges they have applied to before deciding on one.

Class Rank

A measurement of how your academic achievement compares with that of other students in your grade. This number is usually determined by using a weighted GPA that takes into account both your grades and the difficulty of the courses you've taken.

Co-op

A type of work-study program in which students are full-time students but alternate between full-time employment and full-time study.

Coalition Application

A standard application form accepted by members of the Coalition for Access, Affordability, and Success. You can use this application to apply to any of the more than 90 colleges and universities that are members of the Coalition.

**College Application
Essay**

An essay that a college requires students to write and submit as part of their application. Some colleges offer applicants specific questions to answer, while others simply ask applicants to write about themselves. Colleges may refer to this as a "personal statement."

College Credit

What you get when you successfully complete a college-level course. You need a certain number of credits to graduate with a degree. Colleges may also grant credit for scores on exams, such as those offered by the College Board's AP Program® and CLEP.

College Entrance Examination Board (CEEB)/ACT Code

CEEB codes are numbers that identify specific universities or organizations. The College Board created this number code system to ensure that students send their test scores to the right university/organization. Each university has their own CEEB code. This code might be different for the SAT and the ACT.

Common Application

A standard application form is accepted by all colleges that are members of the Common Application Association. You can fill out this application once and submit it to any one — or several — of the nearly 700 colleges that accept it.

Deferred Admission

Permission from a college that has accepted you to postpone enrolling in the college. The postponement is usually for up to one year.

Early Action (EA)

An option to submit your applications before the regular deadlines. When you apply early action, you get admission decisions from colleges earlier than usual. Early action plans are not binding, which means that you do not have to enroll in a college if you are accepted early action. Some colleges have an early action option called EA II, which has a later application deadline than their regular EA plan.

Early Decision (ED)

An option to submit an application to your first-choice college before the regular deadline. When you apply early decision, you get an admission decision earlier than usual. Early decision plans are binding. You agree to enroll in the college immediately if admitted and offered a financial aid package that meets your needs. Some colleges have an early decision option called ED II, which has a later application deadline than their regular ED plan.

FAFSA (Free Application for Federal Student Aid)

A form that current and prospective college students (both in undergraduate and graduate studies) fill out annually to determine eligibility for financial aid. Students who are eligible to for this application are American students or students that have taxes in the U.S.

FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act)

This act gives students the right to view all their educational records (including the letters of recommendation) if the student is 18 or older, or if the student's university releases the recommendation later on. When a student applies to college, they are asked to waive this right to maintain confidentiality between the institution they are applying to and the recommender.

Financial Aid

Money is given or loaned to you to help pay for college. Financial aid can come from federal and state governments, colleges, and private organizations.

Fraternity

This is the term used for a group of male students in the university. This group of male students will live together throughout university and aim to form a strong bond with each other to maintain friendship throughout life. Oftentimes, the members of the society can be associated together due to a common belief, religious or not or for secular aims.

Freshmen

This is the term used for a first-year student in undergraduate studies.

Grade Point Average (GPA)

A number that shows overall academic performance. It's computed by assigning a point value to each grade you earn in each class. Each school system has its own GPA scale. For example, some schools might have a maximum of 4.0 while other schools might have a maximum of 5.0 GPA. The point values for each letter grade a student earns in a class might also be different according to each school system. For this reason, universities often recalculate all applicants' GPA numbers by converting the student's letter grades to their own GPA system. See also Weighted Grade Point Average.

Independent study

An academic course that allows students to earn credit for work done outside of the normal classroom setting. The reading or research assignment is usually designed by the students themselves or with the help of a faculty member, who monitors the progress.

Ivy League

An association of eight private universities located in the northeastern United States, was originally formed as an athletic conference. Today, the term is associated with universities that are considered highly competitive and prestigious. The Ivy League consists of the highly ranked Brown University, Columbia University, Cornell University, Dartmouth College, Harvard University, Princeton University, University of Pennsylvania, and Yale University.

Junior

This is the term used for a third-year student in undergraduate studies.

Legacy Applicant

A college applicant with a relative (usually a parent or grandparent) who graduated from that college. Some colleges give preference to legacy applicants (also called “legacies”).

Letter of Recommendation

The US process requires two types of LORs: teacher and counselor. These letters offer the college admissions officers a different POV on the student (in the classroom setting or in the school community) and allow the university to get to know the student as an individual and not only as an academic student.

Liberal Arts College

A postsecondary institution that emphasizes an undergraduate education in liberal arts. The majority of liberal arts colleges have small student bodies, do not offer graduate studies, and focus on faculty teaching rather than research.

Major	The academic subject area that a student chooses to focus on during his or her undergraduate studies.
Minor	An academic subject area that a student chooses to have a secondary focus on during their undergraduate studies.
National Honor Society	This is an honors group that aims to recognize outstanding high school students. The college admissions process recognises participation and membership of this group. The society stands by four pillars: excellence in the areas of scholarship, service, leadership, and character.
Need-Blind Admission	A policy of making admission decisions without considering the financial circumstances of applicants. Colleges that use this policy may not offer enough financial aid to meet a student's full need.
Open Admission	A policy of accepting any high school graduate, no matter what his or her grades are until all spaces in the incoming class are filled. Almost all two-year community colleges have an open-admission policy. However, a college with a general open-admission policy may have admission requirements for certain programs.

Placement Tests	Tests that measure the academic skills needed for college-level work. They cover reading, writing, math, and sometimes other subjects. Placement test results help determine what courses you are ready for and whether you would benefit from remedial classes.
Pre-orientation Programs	These are usually one-week-long programs that are meant to allow students to make new friends through different themed activities (hiking trips, leadership-building programs, community service, theater productions). Although orientation is mandatory and open to every student, pre-orientation programs are selective.
Priority Date or Deadline	The date by which your application — whether it's for college admission, student housing, or financial aid — must be received to be given the strongest consideration.
Private school	A postsecondary institution controlled by a private individual(s) or a nongovernmental agency. A private institution is usually not supported primarily by public funds and its programs are not operated by publicly elected or appointed officials.
Registrar	The college official who registers students. The registrar may also be responsible for keeping permanent records and maintaining your student file.

Rolling Admission

An admission policy of considering each application as soon as all required information (such as high school records and test scores) has been received, rather than setting an application deadline and reviewing applications in a batch. Colleges that use a rolling admission policy usually notify applicants of admission decisions quickly.

SAT

The College Board's standardized college admission test. It features three main sections: math, reading, and writing, which includes a written essay.

SAT Subject Tests

Hour-long, content-based college admission tests that allow you to showcase achievement in specific subject areas: English, history, math, science, and languages. Some colleges use Subject Tests to place students into the appropriate courses as well as in admission decisions. Based on your performance on the test(s), you could potentially fulfill basic requirements or earn credit for introductory-level courses.

Senior

This is the term used for a fourth-year student in undergraduate studies.

Sophomore Standing

The status of a second-year student. A college may grant sophomore standing to an incoming freshman if he or she has earned college credits through courses, exams, or other programs.

Sorority

This is the term used for a society of female students in the university. This may also be known as a "Greek Letter Organisation." The goal of this type of group is for a strong bond to be formed between the members of the society that will last during all of university but also throughout life.

Supplemental Essay/Questions

These questions are part of the college application and vary per university and program. They offer the student another opportunity to communicate what type of individual they are or highlight an achievement/endeavor. Some schools might require eight short responses while others might require two long responses.

Transcript

The official record of your coursework at a school or college. Your high school transcript is usually required for college admission and for some financial aid packages.

Transfer Student

A student who enrolls in a college after having attended another college.

Undergraduate

A college student who is working toward an associate or a bachelor's degree.

Universal College Application

A standard application form is accepted by all colleges that are Universal College Application members. You can fill out this application once and submit it to any one — or several — of the more than 3,044 colleges that accept it.

Unweighted Grade Point Average

This type of GPA system rewards an equal amount of points for AP courses and regular high school courses. For example, if a school GPA system is out of 4.0 points, a regular A in a normal high school class will be awarded 4.0 points, and an A in an AP course will also be awarded 4.0 points.

Waiting List

The list of applicants who may be admitted to a college if space becomes available. Colleges wait to hear if all the students they accept decide to attend. If students don't enroll and there are empty spots, a college may fill them with students who are on the waiting list.

Weighted Grade Point Average (GPA)

A grade point average is calculated using a system that assigns a higher point value to grades in more difficult classes. In the American system, AP courses will be awarded more points for the GPA of a student than a regular school class. If a school GPA system is out of 4.0, a regular A in a normal high school class will be awarded 4.0 points. However, an A in an AP course might be awarded 4.3 points or 5.0 points depending on the school.

